

The Super Six Excel Playbook

The 6 formulas every small business owner needs
to save 5+ hours every week

Identify · Build · Automate

6

Formulas

5+

Hours Saved Per Week

30 min

Read Time



Welcome to the Playbook

You open Excel every day. But chances are, you're still doing a lot of things by hand.

You're copy-pasting data. You're scrolling through rows to find things. You're updating the same numbers over and over again.

Here's the thing. Excel can do all of that for you. You just need to tell it how.

This playbook gives you 6 formulas. These are the 6 I'd teach any small business owner first. They cover the most common jobs you do in a spreadsheet. And once they're set up, they save you real time every single week.

This playbook is for you if:

- You use Excel for your business but still do a lot of it manually
- You've heard of formulas but never felt confident using them
- You want to save time without taking a course or watching hours of videos

Tip: You don't need to be a spreadsheet expert. If you can type in a cell, you can use these formulas.

The I.B.A. Method

This playbook follows a simple 3-step process:

1**Identify**

Find the part of your workday where Excel is costing you the most time.

2**Build**

Set up the formula that fixes it. Follow the step-by-step example in each chapter.

3**Automate**

Wire the formulas together so your spreadsheet runs on its own.

Before You Start

A few quick things to check before you dive in.

What version of Excel do you have?

These formulas work in Excel 2016 and later. Most of them work in Google Sheets too.

One formula in this playbook is XLOOKUP. That one needs Excel 2019 or Microsoft 365. If you're on an older version, don't worry. I'll show you VLOOKUP as a backup. It does the same job.

Tip: Not sure what version you have? Go to File > Account in Excel and it'll tell you.

How to use each chapter:

- Read the "What It Does" section first. Understand the problem it solves.
- Look at the example. It uses a real business scenario, not made-up data.
- Follow the steps in your own spreadsheet.
- Do the Quick Win Challenge at the end. It takes 5 minutes and locks in the learning.

How the 6 formulas connect:

Each formula stands on its own. But they're even more powerful together. By the end of the playbook, you'll see how to combine them into a simple business dashboard that updates itself.

Note: Start with IF. It's the most useful formula you'll ever learn, and it'll make the rest of this playbook click faster.

Formula 1: IF

Tell Excel to spot problems for you automatically.

What it does:

IF checks something and gives you one answer if it's true, and a different answer if it's false. That's it.

Think of it like this. You're telling Excel: "If this thing is true, show me X. If it's not, show me Y."

The syntax:

```
=IF(logical_test, value_if_true, value_if_false)
```

Part	What It Means	Example
logical_test	The question you're asking	A2 > 30
value_if_true	What to show if the answer is yes	"Overdue"
value_if_false	What to show if the answer is no	"On time"

Real business example: Invoice tracker

You have a list of invoices. Column A is the client name. Column B is how many days since you sent the invoice. You want Excel to flag anything over 30 days as overdue.

```
=IF(B2>30,"Overdue","On time")
```

Copy that formula down the whole column. Every invoice gets checked instantly. No scrolling, no manual checking.

Formula 1: IF (continued)

Step by step:

1 Set up your data

Put your invoice list in a spreadsheet. Column A = client name. Column B = days since invoice sent.

2 Type the formula

In cell C2, type: `=IF(B2>30,"Overdue","On time")`

3 Copy it down

Click C2. Drag the little square in the bottom-right corner all the way down your list. Excel applies the formula to every row.

4 Filter by 'Overdue'

Now you can sort or filter column C to see all overdue invoices at the top in seconds.

Tip: You can use IF to flag anything. Low stock levels, missed targets, unpaid orders. If Excel can check a number or word, IF can flag it.

What about nested IF?

You can put an IF inside another IF. For example: "If it's over 60 days, show 'Urgent'. If it's over 30 days, show 'Overdue'. Otherwise show 'On time'."

```
=IF(B2>60,"Urgent",IF(B2>30,"Overdue","On time"))
```

Use this sparingly. If you're nesting more than two IFs, there's usually a cleaner way to do it.

QUICK WIN CHALLENGE

Open a spreadsheet you use regularly. Find one column where you manually check a condition. Write an IF formula to do that check for you.

Formula 2: COUNTIF

Count things without doing it yourself.

What it does:

COUNTIF counts how many cells in a range match a condition. That's it.

Without it, you're scrolling through a list counting things manually, or filtering and checking the count at the bottom. With COUNTIF, you just type one formula and you get the answer instantly.

The syntax:

```
=COUNTIF(range, criteria)
```

Part	What It Means	Example
range	The cells you want to search through	B2:B100
criteria	What you're looking for	"Paid"

Real business example: Order status tracker

You have a list of orders. Column B has the status of each one: "Paid", "Pending", or "Cancelled". You want to know how many are in each category.

```
=COUNTIF(B2:B100,"Paid")
```

Change "Paid" to "Pending" or "Cancelled" and you get those counts too. Three formulas. Instant answers.

Formula 2: COUNTIF (continued)

Step by step:

1 Set up your list

Make sure the column you want to count has consistent values. 'Paid', 'paid', and 'PAID' are treated as the same, but 'Payed' is different. Spell things the same way every time.

2 Type the formula

In an empty cell, type: `=COUNTIF(B2:B100,"Paid")` . Change B2:B100 to match your actual range.

3 Create a summary table

Set up a small table to one side: Column 1 = status names, Column 2 = COUNTIF formula. Now you have a live summary that updates every time you add a row.

Tip: Use COUNTIFS (with an S) if you need to count based on two conditions at once. For example: count orders that are 'Paid' AND from a specific region.

Other things you can count:

What you want to count	Example formula
Orders over £500	<code>=COUNTIF(C2:C100,">500")</code>
Cells that aren't blank	<code>=COUNTIF(A2:A100,"<>")</code>
A specific client's orders	<code>=COUNTIF(A2:A100,"Smith Ltd")</code>

QUICK WIN CHALLENGE

Find a column in your spreadsheet with repeating values. Write a COUNTIF formula to count how many times each value appears. Build a mini summary table from it.

Formula 3: SUMIF

Add up numbers by category without filtering.

What it does:

SUMIF adds up numbers in one column, but only for rows that match a condition in another column.

Think of it like this. You have a list of all your expenses. Some are "Marketing", some are "Supplies", some are "Travel". You want to know the total for each category. Without SUMIF, you're filtering and checking totals manually. With SUMIF, you get every category total with one formula each.

The syntax:

```
=SUMIF(range, criteria, sum_range)
```

Part	What It Means	Example
range	The column with your categories	A2:A200
criteria	The category you want to total	"Marketing"
sum_range	The column with the numbers to add up	B2:B200

Real business example: Expenses by category

Column A has your expense category. Column B has the cost. You want to see your total marketing spend this month.

```
=SUMIF(A2:A200,"Marketing",B2:B200)
```

Run that once for each category. You get a full expense breakdown in seconds.

Formula 3: SUMIF (continued)

Step by step:

1 Set up your data

Column A = category (e.g. Marketing, Supplies, Travel). Column B = the number you want to add up (e.g. cost, revenue, quantity).

2 Build your summary table

In a new area of the spreadsheet, list each category in column D. In column E, write your SUMIF formula next to each one.

3 Reference the category cell

Instead of typing the category name in quotes, point to the cell. Use `=SUMIF(A2:A200,D2,B2:B200)`. Then drag the formula down the column. Excel updates D2, D3, D4 automatically.

Tip: Use SUMIFS (with an S) to add up based on two conditions. For example: total marketing spend in March only.

More ways to use SUMIF:

Goal	Formula example
Total revenue over £1,000	<code>=SUMIF(B2:B200,">1000",C2:C200)</code>
Total for one specific client	<code>=SUMIF(A2:A200,"Smith Ltd",B2:B200)</code>
Total for all clients except one	<code>=SUMIF(A2:A200,"<>Smith Ltd",B2:B200)</code>

QUICK WIN CHALLENGE

Go to your expense or income spreadsheet. Set up a SUMIF formula that totals one category. Then build a full summary table using the same formula for each category.

Formula 4: XLOOKUP and VLOOKUP

Pull data from another sheet or table in seconds.

What it does:

XLOOKUP finds a value in one column and returns matching information from another column. It's like a search function inside Excel.

Say you have a master price list on one sheet and an order form on another. Instead of manually looking up each price, XLOOKUP does it for you the moment you type a product name.

XLOOKUP syntax (Excel 2019 and Microsoft 365):

`=XLOOKUP(lookup_value, lookup_array, return_array)`

Part	What It Means	Example
lookup_value	What you're searching for	A2 (the product name)
lookup_array	Where to search	Products!A2:A100
return_array	What to return	Products!B2:B100 (the price)

Real business example: Product price lookup

Sheet 1 (Products) has a list of product names in column A and prices in column B. Sheet 2 (Orders) has order lines where you type a product name in column A and want the price to appear in column B automatically.

`=XLOOKUP(A2,Products!A:A,Products!B:B)`

Formula 4: XLOOKUP and VLOOKUP (continued)

Step by step:

1 Set up your lookup table

Make sure your master list (product names and prices) is on a separate sheet or a clean table. Give it clear column headers.

2 Type the XLOOKUP formula

In your orders sheet, click the cell where you want the price to appear. Type the formula, pointing to the product name cell as your lookup value.

3 Copy it down

Drag the formula down the column. As you add new product names in column A, the price fills in automatically.

Tip: Add a fourth argument to handle errors cleanly: `=XLOOKUP(A2,Products!A:A,Products!B:B,"Not found")`. This stops #N/A errors appearing when a product isn't in the list.

Using VLOOKUP instead (older Excel versions):

```
=VLOOKUP(A2,Products!A:B,2,FALSE)
```

Argument	Meaning
A2	What to look up
Products!A:B	The table to search (must start with the lookup column)
2	Which column number to return (B is the 2nd column)
FALSE	Find an exact match only

Note: VLOOKUP only searches left to right. XLOOKUP can search in any direction. Use XLOOKUP if you have it.

QUICK WIN CHALLENGE

Create a product or service price list on one sheet. Then use XLOOKUP (or VLOOKUP) to pull those prices into an invoice or order form on another sheet.

Formula 5: INDEX/MATCH

The most powerful lookup in Excel. Works in any direction.

What it does:

INDEX/MATCH is a two-formula combination. It does what VLOOKUP does, but without the limitations.

MATCH finds the position of your search value in a list. INDEX uses that position to grab the value from any other column. Together, they can look left, right, up, down, and handle much more complex setups.

The syntax:

```
=INDEX(return_range, MATCH(lookup_value, lookup_range, 0))
```

Part	What It Means	Example
return_range	The column with the values you want back	B2:B100
lookup_value	What you're searching for	D2
lookup_range	The column to search in	A2:A100
0	Find an exact match	Always use 0

Real business example: Find a client's latest rate

You have a rates table. Client names are in column B (not column A). You want to find the rate for a specific client. VLOOKUP can't search column B. INDEX/MATCH can.

```
=INDEX(C2:C100,MATCH(F2,B2:B100,0))
```

F2 = the client name you're searching for. Column C = the rates. Column B = the client names.

Formula 5: INDEX/MATCH (continued)

Step by step:

1 Identify your search value

What are you looking for? A client name? A product code? A date? That goes in the MATCH part.

2 Identify what you want back

What do you want Excel to return? A price? A quantity? A status? The column with those values goes in the INDEX part.

3 Write the formula

Combine them: INDEX finds the value, MATCH tells INDEX which row to look at. The 0 at the end means exact match only.

Tip: When you see #N/A with INDEX/MATCH, it usually means the lookup value isn't in the lookup range. Check your spelling and make sure both ranges are the same length.

Why use INDEX/MATCH instead of XLOOKUP?

If you have Excel 365 or 2019, use XLOOKUP. It's simpler.

INDEX/MATCH is useful when:

- You're on an older version of Excel
- You need to look up values in a two-way table (row and column)
- You're working with very large datasets where XLOOKUP is slower

QUICK WIN CHALLENGE

Find a lookup task in your spreadsheet where VLOOKUP would need the search column to be first. Use INDEX/MATCH instead and see how much easier it is.

Formula 6: IFERROR

Make your spreadsheet look clean and professional.

What it does:

IFERROR wraps around any other formula. If that formula works, you get the normal result. If it hits an error, you get a clean message instead.

Without IFERROR, errors like #N/A, #VALUE!, and #REF! show up in your spreadsheet. They're confusing. They look messy. IFERROR hides them and shows something useful instead.

The syntax:

```
=IFERROR(value, value_if_error)
```

Part	What It Means	Example
value	The formula you want to run	XLOOKUP(A2,Products!A:A,Products!B:B)
value_if_error	What to show if it errors	"Not found"

Real business example: Clean up your lookup results

You're using XLOOKUP to pull product prices into an order form. When a product name isn't in your list yet, you get an ugly #N/A error. IFERROR fixes that.

```
=IFERROR(XLOOKUP(A2,Products!A:A,Products!B:B),"Not found")
```

Now instead of an error, the cell just says "Not found". Clean. Clear. Professional.

Formula 6: IFERROR (continued)

Step by step:

1 Pick a formula that sometimes errors

Any formula that looks something up is a good candidate. XLOOKUP, VLOOKUP, and INDEX/MATCH all return #N/A if they can't find a match.

2 Wrap it in IFERROR

Type `=IFERROR(` before your existing formula, then add a comma and your error message in quotes at the end, then close the bracket.

3 Choose a useful message

Use "Not found" for lookups. Use "Check data" if something might be wrong. Use 0 if you want blank-ish results in calculations.

Tip: You can use 0 or "" (empty string) as the error value if you don't want any text to appear. This is useful in sum or count formulas where an error would break the total.

Common uses:

Situation	What to use as error value
Lookup returns #N/A	"Not found" or ""
Formula breaks if cell is blank	0 or ""
Sharing with a client	"Please check" or "N/A"
Used in a SUM formula	0

QUICK WIN CHALLENGE

Take any lookup formula you've built in this playbook and wrap it in IFERROR. Give it a clean error message. Test it by searching for something that doesn't exist in your list.

Wiring Them Together: The Formula Stack

How all 6 formulas work as one system.

Each formula on its own saves you time. But the real magic happens when you combine them.

Here's how a typical small business spreadsheet might use all 6 together:

Formula	What It Does in Your System	Where to Put It
XLOOKUP	Pulls the price for each product from your master list	Order form, column B
IFERROR	Wraps XLOOKUP so blank rows stay clean	Same cell as XLOOKUP
IF	Flags orders as 'Shipped' or 'Pending' based on date	Status column
COUNTIF	Counts how many orders are still pending	Summary dashboard
SUMIF	Totals revenue by product category	Summary dashboard
INDEX/MATCH	Finds the latest price for a specific client	Client-facing quote sheet

The idea: Each formula handles one job. Together they create a spreadsheet that mostly runs itself.

Note: You don't need to use all 6 in every spreadsheet. Start with the 2 or 3 that solve your biggest problems right now. Add the others as you need them.

A Simple Business Dashboard

Here's a practical example. You run a small product-based business. You want one dashboard that shows you the key numbers without you having to calculate anything manually.

What your dashboard needs:

Dashboard cell	Formula to use	What it shows
Total revenue this month	SUMIF	Revenue for rows marked as paid in this month
Orders pending	COUNTIF	Count of orders with status 'Pending'
Orders shipped today	COUNTIF	Count of orders shipped today
Biggest order this month	MAX + IF (array)	Highest single order value
Price of a specific product	XLOOKUP	Live price from your product list

Set this up once. Every time you add a row to your order sheet, your dashboard updates itself.

The mindset shift:

Right now, you probably go into your spreadsheet to find information. After you build this, your spreadsheet gives you the information. You just look at the dashboard.

Tip: Build the order log first. Get the data in one clean table. Then build the dashboard formulas pointing at that table. Clean data in = clean answers out.

Your Weekend Build Plan

Turn what you've learned into a live spreadsheet in two days.

You don't need to build everything at once. This plan gets your most important formulas working this weekend.

1 Saturday morning (30 minutes): Identify

Open the spreadsheet you use most. Ask yourself: where am I still doing things by hand? Where am I copying and pasting? Where am I manually counting or totalling things? Write down the top 3 tasks that take the most time.

2 Saturday afternoon (60 minutes): Build your first formula

Pick the formula from this playbook that solves your biggest problem. IF for flagging things. SUMIF or COUNTIF for totalling or counting. XLOOKUP for pulling data from another sheet. Set it up using the step-by-step guide from the relevant chapter.

3 Sunday (60 minutes): Add the next two formulas

Once your first formula is working, add the next two on your list. By Sunday evening you should have 3 formulas running in a real spreadsheet you use every week.

4 Week 1: Wire them together

Set up a simple summary area at the top of your spreadsheet. Use your COUNTIF and SUMIF formulas to build 3 to 5 key numbers that update automatically.

Note: Don't try to build everything perfectly. A messy formula that works is better than a perfect one you never start.

Common Errors and How to Fix Them

What Excel is trying to tell you when something goes wrong.

Error	What it means	How to fix it
#N/A	Can't find the value you searched for	Check your spelling. Make sure the value exists in the lookup range. Wrap with IFERROR.
#VALUE!	Something in the formula isn't the right type	Check you're not mixing text and numbers. Make sure number cells aren't stored as text.
#REF!	A cell reference in your formula is broken	Usually happens when you delete a row or column. Check the formula for missing references.
#NAME?	Excel doesn't recognise the formula name	Check your spelling. COUNIF instead of COUNTIF is a common one.
#DIV/0!	You're dividing by zero or a blank cell	Wrap with IFERROR or add an IF to check the denominator isn't zero first.

The 3 most common beginner mistakes:

1

Mixing text and numbers

If a number is stored as text, formulas like SUMIF won't count it. Check by looking at the cell alignment. Numbers align right. Text aligns left.

2

Ranges that don't match

In SUMIF and COUNTIF, the criteria range and sum range must be the same size. A2:A100 and B2:B50 will cause problems.

3

Forgetting to lock references

If your formula moves when you copy it down and it shouldn't, use \$ signs: \$A\$1 stays fixed. Use F4 to toggle locking on and off.

Your Bonuses

Three extra resources to help you get results faster.

Bonus 1

The Formula Cheat Sheet

All 6 formulas on one page. Syntax, a quick example, and what each one is for. Pin it up next to your screen or save it to your desktop. You'll use it every week.

Included on the next page of this playbook.

Bonus 2

The Pre-Built Excel Template

A ready-made Excel file with all 6 formulas already set up. Just add your own data. It includes an order log, a product list, and a summary dashboard. Download it, open it, and start using it today.

Check your purchase confirmation email for the download link.

Bonus 3

The Formula Troubleshooting Guide

The most common errors and how to fix them. You just read this on page 19. Keep coming back to it when something breaks.

Pages 19 of this playbook.

Note: If you can't find your download email, search your inbox for 'Sheets Wizard'. Still can't find it? Message @realsheetswizard on TikTok.

Formula Cheat Sheet

All 6 formulas at a glance. Print this page and pin it up.

Formula	Syntax	What it does	Example
IF	=IF(test, true, false)	Checks a condition and shows one of two results	=IF(B2>30,"Late","OK")
COUNTIF	=COUNTIF(range, criteria)	Counts cells that match a condition	=COUNTIF(B2:B100,"Paid")
SUMIF	=SUMIF(range, criteria, sum_range)	Totals numbers that match a condition	=SUMIF(A2:A100,"Marketing",B2:B100)
XLOOKUP	=XLOOKUP(value, lookup, return)	Finds a value and returns matching data	=XLOOKUP(A2,Products!A:A,Products!B:B)
VLOOKUP	=VLOOKUP(value, table, col, FALSE)	Same as XLOOKUP but for older Excel	=VLOOKUP(A2,Products!A:B,2,FALSE)
INDEX/MATCH	=INDEX(return, MATCH(value, range, 0))	Powerful lookup that works in any direction	=INDEX(C2:C100,MATCH(F2,B2:B100,0))
IFERROR	=IFERROR(formula, value_if_error)	Catches errors and shows a clean message instead	=IFERROR(XLOOKUP(...),"Not found")

Tip: Bookmark this page. When you forget a syntax, come back here before you Google it.

What's Next?

You've now got 6 formulas that will save you hours every single week.

The first time you build one of these, it takes a bit of effort. The second time is faster. By the third or fourth time, it feels natural. That's when Excel stops being a spreadsheet and starts being a system that runs your business.

Keep going. Here's what to do now:

1**Build your first formula this weekend**

Don't wait. Open Excel today. Pick one formula from the playbook and set it up in a real spreadsheet you actually use.

2**Come back to the cheat sheet**

Page 21. Every time you forget a syntax, check there first. You'll have it memorised within a week.

3**Follow Sheets Wizard on TikTok**

I post daily tips, formula walkthroughs, and Excel tricks for small business owners. Follow @realsheetswizard for a new tip every day.

4**Tell me what you build**

Seriously. Drop a comment on any TikTok and let me know which formula saved you the most time. I read every one.

READY FOR THE NEXT STEP?

The Formula Playbook

40 Excel formulas that run your business

A 57-page paid reference with 40 more formulas, grouped into 7 themed parts, plus a companion Excel workbook and dashboard starter. Pick it up on Payhip for £9.99.

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Excel education for small business owners and solopreneurs